01-PROJECT-CHARTER.md

.things that Matter
Project Charter

Document Information	
Company Name	.things that Matter
Document Type	Project Charter
Version	1.0
Date	January 21, 2026
Status	Draft - Pending Approval

1. Executive Summary

1.1 Company Vision

\1 is building the infrastructure for \1 — a paradigm shift where products become portable, self-sovereign digital objects that can be transacted anywhere on the internet without requiring users to visit traditional storefronts.

1.2 The Problem

The internet today is architected around "Places." To purchase an item, users must:
- Navigate to a specific URL
- Load a heavy storefront
- Parse a unique user interface
- Operate within a walled garden

This model is fundamentally broken because it:
- Rigidly couples the product to the platform
- Assumes commerce is a destination, not a capability
- Is inefficient for AI agents (high compute cost to parse HTML/JSON)
- Creates friction in social sharing and discovery

1.3 The Solution

We are building a \1 that transforms product data into portable, intelligent digital objects called \1 (\1 files). These artifacts:

- Carry their own identity, price, semantic meaning, and checkout logic
- Are visually shareable for humans (embedded in images)
- Are computationally efficient for AI agents (binary format)
- Travel freely across the web without platform dependency

1.4 Key Innovation: The Distribution Trinity

Every product processed by our compiler exists simultaneously as:

1. \1: A stunning product image with commerce payload baked into pixels and metadata
2. \1: A \1 protocol link for text-based environments
3. \1: Raw binary file for direct transfer (the "MP3 of Commerce")

2. Business Objectives

2.1 Primary Objectives

Objective	Target	Timeline
Build functional Commerce Compiler	MVP operational	August 2026
Launch browser extension	Chrome Web Store	December 2026
Onboard beta merchants	5-10 merchants	Q4 2026
Process product catalog	10,000+ products	Q4 2026
Achieve technical proof-of-concept	End-to-end demo	August 2026

2.2 Success Criteria

Metric	Target
Steganography survival rate	≥50% across platforms
Compiler processing speed	<500ms per product
Browser extension adoption	100+ beta users
Merchant satisfaction	>80% positive feedback
Technical debt ratio	<20% of codebase

2.3 Strategic Positioning

\1 positions as \1, not a marketplace:
- We build the "physics" that allow products to travel freely
- Revenue through compiler API access, not transaction fees
- Open standard encourages ecosystem adoption
- Network effects from \1 format adoption

3. Scope Definition

3.1 In Scope

Component	Description
Commerce Compiler (matter-core)	Rust library that ingests product data and outputs .th
ing files
FlatBuffers Schema	Binary format definition for Universal Commerce Containers
CLIP Integration	Semantic vectorization for product "cognition"
Ed25519 Signing	Cryptographic integrity for tamper-proof files
Steganography Engine	Image embedding for polyglot media distribution
XMP Metadata Injection	Fast discovery layer for crawlers/extensions
matter:// Protocol	Custom URI scheme for text-based distribution
Shadow Index API	Hash-to-artifact resolution service
Cloudflare R2 CDN	Artifact storage and distribution
Browser Extension (Lens)	Chrome extension for product discovery and checkout
libmatter SDK	Developer library with Rust/TypeScript bindings

3.2 Out of Scope (Year 1)

Item	Rationale
Mobile SDK (iOS/Android)	Deferred to Year 2
Self-hosted GPU cluster	Use serverless CLIP initially
SOC2 compliance	No enterprise customers in Year 1
Payment processing	Redirect to merchant checkout
Inventory management	Merchants handle fulfillment
Customer support platform	Manual support initially

3.3 Dependencies

Dependency	Type	Risk Level
Replicate API (CLIP)	External service	Medium
Cloudflare R2	Infrastructure	Low
Chrome Web Store	Distribution	Low
FlatBuffers library	Open source	Low
Rust toolchain	Development	Low

4. Stakeholders

4.1 Core Team

Role	Name	Responsibilities
CEO	Sobuhle Nyambali	Strategy, partnerships, fundraising
CTO	Matome Mboweni	Technical architecture, development, delivery

4.2 Target Users

User Type	Description	Primary Need
Merchants	E-commerce businesses	Distribute products beyond their storefront
Consumers	Online shoppers	Discover and purchase without friction
AI Agents	Autonomous commerce bots	Efficient product data parsing
Developers	Third-party integrators	Easy SDK for Matter-enabled apps

4.3 External Stakeholders

Stakeholder	Interest
Investors	ROI, market traction
Platform partners	Integration opportunities
Open-source community	Standard adoption

5. Project Governance

5.1 Decision-Making Authority

Decision Type	Authority

Strategic direction	CEO
Technical architecture	CTO
Budget allocation	CEO + CTO jointly
Feature prioritization	CTO (with CEO input)
Partnership agreements	CEO
Hiring decisions	CEO + CTO jointly

5.2 Communication Cadence

Meeting	Frequency	Participants	Purpose
Strategy sync	Weekly	CEO + CTO	Alignment, blockers
Progress demo	Monthly	CEO + CTO	Working software review
Investor update	Quarterly	CEO	Progress report

5.3 Reporting Structure

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CEO (Sobuhle Nyambali)
  CTO (Matome Mboweni)
       Development (solo initially)
       Future: Engineering team
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6. Constraints & Assumptions

6.1 Constraints

Constraint	Impact
Budget: R72,000 Year 1	Lean development, free tiers prioritized
Solo developer	Sequential work, no parallelization
11-month timeline	Extended from 9 months due to budget
No security audit budget	Self-review until revenue allows

6.2 Assumptions

Assumption	Risk if Invalid
Steganography survives ≥50% of platforms	Pivot to matter:// primary distribution
CLIP serverless costs remain stable	May need self-hosted GPU
Chrome allows extension publishing	May need alternative distribution
Rust learning curve manageable	C/C++ background accelerates learning
Merchants interested in beta	Extended timeline for adoption

7. Budget Summary

7.1 Year 1 Budget: R72,000

Category	Amount (ZAR)	% of Total
Development Tools	R6,048	8%
AI & ML APIs	R21,600	30%
Infrastructure & Hosting	R7,560	10%
Monitoring & Operations	R0	0%

Payments & Financial	R10,800	15%
Domains & Publishing	R500	1%
One-Time Costs	R2,800	4%
Buffer (5%)	R3,600	5%
Operating Reserve	**R19,092**	**27%**

7.2 Monthly Burn Rate

Phase	Monthly Avg	Duration
Setup (Month 1-2)	R7,250	2 months
Development (Month 3-7)	R6,100	5 months
Launch prep (Month 8-11)	R6,550	4 months

8. High-Level Timeline

8.1 Phase Overview

Phase	Duration	Key Deliverable
Phase 0: Validation	Feb 2026 (4 weeks)	Steganography proof-of-concept
Phase 1: Foundation	Mar-Apr 2026	FlatBuffers schema, Rust compiler
Phase 2: Core	May-Jul 2026	CLIP integration, signing, steg engine
Phase 3: Distribution	Aug-Sep 2026	CDN, Shadow Index, browser extension
Phase 4: Launch	Oct-Dec 2026	Beta merchants, public release

8.2 Key Milestones

Milestone	Target Date	Success Criteria
Phase 0 Go/No-Go	Feb 28, 2026	≥50% steganography survival
50% completion	Jun 30, 2026	Working compiler + CLIP
75% completion	Aug 31, 2026	Browser extension functional
Beta launch	Oct 31, 2026	5 merchants onboarded
Public launch	Dec 15, 2026	Chrome Web Store published

9. Risk Summary

9.1 Top Risks

Risk	Probability	Impact	Mitigation
Steganography fails on major platforms	Medium	High	Phase 0 validation, matter:// fallback
Cursor Pro limits slow development	Medium	Medium	Batch work, use slow requests
Rust learning takes longer	Low	Medium	C/C++ background provides strong foundation
No merchant interest	Low	High	Open-source for developer adoption
Budget overrun	Medium	Medium	5% buffer, strict scope control

9.2 Risk Tolerance

Risk Type	Tolerance
Technical risk	High (can pivot approaches)

Timeline risk	Medium (2-month buffer acceptable)
Budget risk	Low (fixed allocation)
Security risk	Medium (self-review until audit)

10. Approval

10.1 Charter Approval

By signing below, stakeholders approve this Project Charter and authorize the project to proceed.

Role	Name	Signature	Date
CEO	Sobuhle Nyambali	_____	___/___/2026
CTO	Matome Mboweni	_____	___/___/2026

10.2 Change Control

Changes to this charter require written approval from both CEO and CTO. Minor updates (clarifications, typos) may be made by CTO with notification to CEO.

11. Document Control

Version	Date	Author	Changes
1.0	Jan 21, 2026	M. Mboweni	Initial draft

\1 Technical Architecture Document